

the uncompromising Gandhian whose righteous reproach of Nehruvian development economics alienated him from his own fold.

There are authoritative sketches of foreigners who gave back to this land, from Scottish town-planner Patrick Geddes, forest anthropologist Verrier Elwin, Gandhi's disciple Madeleine Slade/Mira Behn, to the organic farmer couple Albert and Gabrielle Howard.

The book is a culmination of a chronicle Guha began over three decades ago. *The Unquiet Woods* (1990) is a history of the Chipko movement. *This Fissured Land* (1992), with ecologist Madhav Gadgil, is an ecological history of India. The duo also wrote the policy-oriented *Ecology and Equity* (1995). "Environmentalism is about social justice and equal access," says Guha. "Poor countries like India need to care more about environmental sustainability because they have higher population densities and fragile ecologies. The livelihood and health of several hundred million Indians are adversely affected by multiple forms of environmental degradation."

Finding answers begins with going beyond admiring nature and opening the dialogue with history, then using our knowledge of the past to advocate better policies in the present. For that reason, Guha says, his book is titled 'Speaking with Nature' and not 'Speaking for Nature'. ■

–Bijoy Venugopal

TURNING A NEW LEAF

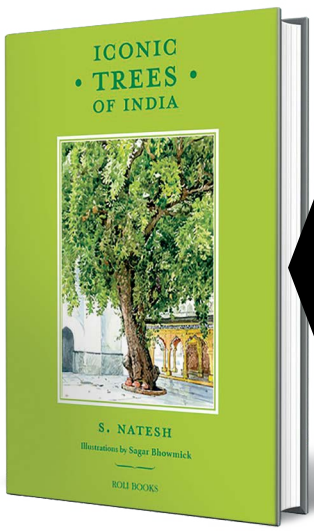
S. Natesh and illustrator **Sagar Bhowmick** celebrate the individuality of India's most iconic trees

Since the turn of the century, we have lost hundreds of thousands of trees. Many had stood for centuries, weathering storms, wars, droughts and famines. They paid the price for standing in the way of eight-lane highways, metro rail lines and SEZs. In atonement, we have supplanted their memory with nameless clones in landscaped hedgerows.

A tree sprouts from a minuscule seed that lies dormant in the soil until the conditions are right for it to seek the sky. It lays claim to a parcel of earth and weathers the vagaries of time, in the process testing destiny and often writing it.

How can we not marvel at this magnificent living thing?

I think that I shall never see/ A poem lovely as a tree, gushed poet Joyce Kilmer. So does S. Natesh, a scientist who once taught botany at the University of Delhi. He sees India's iconic trees as one may see people–with names, addresses and idiosyncrasies.



ICONIC TREES OF INDIA: 75 NATURAL WONDERS
by S. Natesh
ILLUSTRATOR
Sagar Bhowmick
ROLI BOOKS
₹1995; 256 pages

Trees become synonymous with places. With some licence, the title of Anees Jung's memoir *When a Place Becomes a Person* can be applied to describing the 75 protagonists of this book. Natesh has made pilgrimages to absorb the essence of each individual tree.

Among these luminaries are aliens and aborigines, natives and exotics. Included here is a saintly peepal, which mocks the pettiness of the Radcliffe Line that cleaves India and Pakistan by stretching boughs into both countries. In Andhra's Gootibylu village is a sprawling banyan that straddles four acres. There is a Ber under which Guru Nanak gave counsel to a king. There are African baobabs of mysterious origin that survived bloody battles. And there is the loneliest tree in India–a Giant Sequoia native to California, which was planted in the yard of an institute in Jammu.

Many Indians believe that our trees, like our scriptures, are older than time. However, Natesh uses scientific criteria–the study of growth rings and radiocarbon dating–to determine a tree's age.

A new addition to the dendrophile's bookshelf, *Iconic Trees of India* is no mere field guide. It is an anthology of tenderly told biographies balancing scientific temper, natural history and wonder. Opulently illustrated by Sagar Bhowmick, this book is an endearing almanac feting India's most prominent senior citizens. ■

–Bijoy Venugopal